

Cowork, in one page

Describe the outcome. Point it at a copy. Read it before it goes out.

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Not the steps. "Build me a spreadsheet of what I spent" — not "open this file, now copy that number."

Point it at a copy.

Always, until you're comfortable. It's free, it takes four seconds, and it's the difference between trying things and being careful.

Read it before it goes out.

Drafts are free. Sent is permanent. That's the whole email rule and it's the whole customer rule.

THE FOUR MOVES

1 Connect a folder

Unzip it first. In the Claude app, switch the message box from **Chat** to **Cowork**, then point it at that one folder.

This folder is eight months of paperwork from my flower shop and none of the filenames mean anything. Look at what's actually inside each file, then sort everything into folders that make sense for a small business. Rename anything whose name doesn't say what it is. Tell me what you're going to do before you do it.

3 Search and draft email

Connect it once: **Customize** in the left sidebar > **Connectors** > **Gmail**. Ask first: *What's in my inbox that I haven't answered and should have?*

Draft a reply to [WHO]. [HOW IT SHOULD SOUND — warm, brief, apologetic, firm — your call.] Save it as a draft. Do not send it.

2 Turn a pile into a file

Same folder, still connected. No attaching files one by one. Then ask: *Is there anything on these invoices I should be annoyed about?*

Go through every invoice and receipt in this folder, including the photos, and build me one spreadsheet with a row for each one: date, who I paid, what it was for, and the amount. Add a total at the bottom. Save it in this folder as expenses.xlsx.

4 Teach it a job once

Answer its questions, then turn the skill on at **Customize** > **Skills**. Fix it later by telling it the one thing it got wrong.

I want to make a skill for [THE JOB], so I never have to explain my format again. Here's how I do it: [YOUR RULES, in plain sentences]. When it's finished it should [DONE LOOKS LIKE]. Ask me anything you need, then build it.

THE WORDS

Cowork — the mode where Claude works on real files in a folder you pick, instead of you uploading things one at a time. Same app, same account.

Connector — a door between Claude and something you already use: your email, your calendar, your file storage.

Plugin — a bundle of connectors and know-how for a kind of work, installed in one step instead of assembled piece by piece. Same place: **Customize** > **Plugins**.

Skill — instructions for one job you do over and over, saved once. Claude picks it up on its own when that job comes around.

WHEN IT GOES WRONG

- 1 Unzip the file first.** Claude can't see inside a zip. Windows: right-click > **Extract All**. Mac: double-click. Then connect the **extracted folder**.
- 2 No spreadsheet or document got made.** Initials (bottom-left) > **Settings** > **Capabilities** > turn on "Code execution and file creation".
- 3 Not sure a skill is live?** Open **Customize** > **Skills**. If it's listed with its toggle on, it's installed.
- 4 It's just sitting there.** It isn't stuck. Cowork takes a minute or three because it's doing real work. Don't retype.
- 5 Your skill didn't fire.** Start a **new Cowork session** — skills load when a session starts. Then ask for it by name and improve its description.